politicians and the press to bolster his case: in the process, demeaning himself and his Service further'.

In this vein, the recent unfortunate controversy about the age of the previous army chief, General V.K. Singh, has saddened many of us. Since my name has been mentioned in this regard in some motivated articles and talk shows on the TV, I would like to clear the air on this issue. The fact that every soldier's honour is equally important needs no reiteration. Thus, I consider it appropriate to express my views now, lest my silence be misconstrued.

The 'age row' has its genesis with the contradictory dates of birth (DoB) entered in the threshold documents submitted by the general officer himself in the mid-1960s. The problem surfaced almost forty years later, when this discrepancy was pointed out by the ministry of defence in April 2006, while processing the papers of this officer's batch for promotion from major general to lieutenant general. Accordingly, the Army HQ (MS Branch) wrote to then Major General V.K. Singh in May 2006, seeking his clarification on the discrepancy observed. In his reply, the officer claimed that 1951 should be treated as his year of birth and attached certain documents to support his contention. However, after a detailed examination in the Army HQ in August 2006, it was conveyed to him that 'after due consideration of his reply and in view of the existing rules, the request cannot be processed at this belated stage', and therefore 1950 would remain as his recorded year of birth. Thereafter, I was informed of this fact by the military secretary, and was told that the issue had been closed. There was neither an exchange of correspondence directly between the officer concerned and me, nor did he represent or complain against the decision of the Army HQ at that time. In case the officer had any reservations against the decision, he was free to take up the matter with the Army HQ or the ministry of defence by means of a non-statutory or statutory complaint and have the matter resolved one way or the other. Rationally speaking, he should have done so but for reasons best known to him, he chose not to raise the issue then.

Comments made against me recently that this issue was raked up by me in 2006 with a 'succession plan' (*sic*) and parochial agenda in